

TEMPORALITY AND THE PHENOMENAL FIELD: A SENSORY ETHNOGRAPHY OF SEAFARING

A PROPOSAL

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INTRODUCTION

The proposed research investigates the role of aesthetic knowledge in workplaces at sea, through a combination of sensory ethnography, participant observation, and the production of both an ethnographic documentary and text. At the heart of this research project is the question, how does a worker's aesthetic understanding of an environment change over time, and how does this affect the work and the workplace? The project will look at aesthetic knowledge in relation to other forms of knowledge that are vital to working at sea, such as tacit knowledge. This research will build upon previous research on maritime culture conducted en route to a master's degree in visual anthropology from the University of Manchester. By addressing this specific question, I hope to build upon previous anthropological knowledge relating to the areas of aesthetics, the anthropology of work, and maritime culture.

In the following proposal, I will give a brief overview of the research project and how it will relate in both theory and practice to the research specialties of faculty members within the social anthropology department at the University of Manchester. I will then give a brief introduction to literature that I have drawn upon in creating this proposal and how I hope to position my own research in relation to the existing literature. Lastly, I will give a description of the methods that I hope to utilize within my research. By presenting this information, I hope to show how my research would benefit from the unique faculty and facilities of the social anthropology department at the University of Manchester, and also how my research will fit into the current themes focused upon by the department.

PROJECT OVERVIEW

The importance of aesthetic knowledge in seafaring careers became apparent to me during my own ethnographic research with fishermen from the Southeastern United States. Many of the fishermen would comment in passing on the beauty and natural aesthetics of the sea and that the scenery was a major factor in drawing them to this career. In this project, I will begin by investigating the role of aesthetic knowledge as seamen initially enter the world of seafaring, which is linked to the concept of beauty-aesthetics. Many wage-earning seamen could easily earn similar pay in careers on land.

Of course, a variety of factors may lead a person to choose a career as a seaman. It may be that a seaman comes from a society or culture where it is commonplace or expected that they pursue their livelihood at sea. Or perhaps there are specific economic forces that drive seamen to leave the land in pursuit of a livelihood¹. While these factors are often noted for drawing seamen to their jobs, another, equally important factor, is often overlooked: the aesthetics of the sea. The initial aesthetic draw is one that is closely tied to Immanuel Kant's concept of aesthetics. Kantian aesthetics involves the valuation of beauty. For Kant, beauty is not a property of an artwork or a natural phenomenon, but is instead a consciousness of the pleasure that attends the "free play" of the imagination and the understanding (Kant 1951[1790]:pt. 1, sec. 1, bk. 1). Even though it appears that we are using reason to decide that which is beautiful, the judgment is not a cognitive judgment, and is consequently not logical, but aesthetic. It is a certain aesthetic allure of the sea that, at least partially, draws seamen to this career, but once aboard the ship and fully immersed in the seafaring environment, other forms of aesthetic knowledge become necessary to navigate a life at sea.

This other form of aesthetic knowledge can, in simplest form, be described as "sense experience". The use of the term aesthetics in this manner is closely tied to the original definition of the Greek word *aisthētikos*, meaning "perceptive by feeling" (Buck-Morss 1992:6). This form of aesthetics focuses on the phenomenal field². It is my own experience from previous research that over time, beauty aesthetics take a more passive role in the work, and the senses begin to play a vital role in the work being done aboard a boat or ship, whether it is the exteroceptive senses (sight, smell, hearing, touch, and taste) or interoceptive (proprioception, pain, and internal bodily movements). The crew must learn to passively sense changes to ship that can be important to the safety of the crew, for example, hearing from the stern of a boat that the autopilot mechanism, at the bow of the ship, has become disengaged. This example happened during my own fieldwork, and it was not an alarm that alerted the crew to this danger, but simply a subtle change in the soundtrack of life aboard a boat. It was small events, such as this, that have drawn my interest towards studying further the aesthetics of seafaring, specifically, the relationship between aesthetics and time.

¹ Marcus Rediker (1987) notes that throughout the history of seafaring, seamen have been members of a highly mobile wage labor workforce. Rediker cites 18th century sea-cook, Barnaby Rudge, in observing "the vocation of seaman was 'a universal Passport, that renders him welcom, and finds him ready Money, in almost any Corner of the Globe'". (Original spelling) Rediker felt that this tie to an extensive international economy and the abundance of opportunities to earn "real Money" is a key draw to a life at sea.

² According to Donald Snygg and Arthur Combs (1949), the phenomenal field is our subjective reality of the world, including all of the objects and people in that world.

Much of my interest in the role of sense experience in the social began with David MacDougall's Doon School project. In his exploration of aesthetics at the Doon School, David MacDougall was primarily interested in what he calls "social aesthetics". "Aesthetics" in this context has little to do with notions of beauty or art, but rather with a much wider range of culturally patterned sensory experience... closer to what the Greeks originally meant by aisthesis, or "sense experience" (1999:5). I will continue MacDougall's line of inquiry by looking at the sense experiences of seamen as they spend extended periods of time at sea.

My previous example also illustrates the importance of time and aesthetics, to a small extent. Not just any person would possess the correct sensory knowledge to have corrected the situation. I was there, hearing the same sounds, but unable to sense the change in sound and the possible danger attached to that change. It is over time that the aesthetics of the social and physical world become imprinted upon a person. This is a perspective not often touched upon in previous ethnographic research. As Thomas Csordas has pointed out, "anthropologists have isolated the senses, especially focusing on visual perception, but seldom examining the synthesis and interplay of the senses in perceptual life" (1990:35). I hope to steer away from this by relating my aesthetic inquiry back to the workplace of the seafarers, and the international shipping industry as a whole. And while researchers, like MacDougall, have brought aesthetics more into the foreground of anthropological research, little has been written about the connection between aesthetics and temporality. I hope that the research I will conduct while at the University of Manchester will address this gap in the literature.

The University of Manchester's social anthropology department offers a unique research environment that will match very well with my own research interests and goals. The Granada Centre specializes in visual and sensory anthropology, which would make the Centre, and the social anthropology department as a whole, an excellent location for me to study while conducting my dissertation research. I also intend to produce an ethnographic film as part of my PhD in Social Anthropology with Visual Media using an observational filmmaking technique. The Granada Centre is famous for its production of ethnographic films, primarily using the observational filmmaking technique. I feel that this congruence in filmmaking styles will be beneficial to my research project.

While studying at the University of Manchester, I hope to be advised by Andrew Irving of the Granada Centre for Visual Anthropology. Professor Irving's interest in both the senses and temporality would make for an excellent match with the goals of my research. I would also seek additional assistance from Paul Henley in the production of an ethnographic film as part of my dissertation. Lastly, since the majority of my fieldwork will be based in a workplace, I would also seek assistance from Dr. Jens Kjaerulff in conducting a literature review in relation to the anthropology of work. By seeking advisement from this collection of faculty advisors and utilizing each of their unique research backgrounds, I hope to present the strongest dissertation research possible.

POSITIONING THE RESEARCH WITHIN ANTHROPOLOGY

While my research is built around the central question of how a person's aesthetic knowledge changes over time, it is also firmly grounded in several unique and varied areas of study. In the next section I will highlight the key texts that have influenced the direction that my research will take.

Anthropological research on the topic of social aesthetics is a relatively new concept and has become much more frequent in recent years. David MacDougall's ethnographic films, including *The Doon School Chronicles*, and the accompanying texts that have been published in both the *Visual Anthropology Review* and also in MacDougall's collection of essays, *The Corporeal Image*, make the argument that aesthetics are oftentimes overlooked by anthropologists: "the aesthetic dimension of human existence is an important social fact, to be taken seriously alongside such other facts as economic survival, political power, and religious belief" (1999:5). My research takes a cue from MacDougall in placing aesthetics on equal ground with other social forces that are more often focused upon within both maritime studies and social anthropology.

My research also references Pierre Bourdieu's concept of habitus in order to gain a deeper understanding of the relationships between aesthetics, embodied knowledge, and the work of seafaring laborers. The concept was originally introduced by Marcel Mauss as a simple way to organize "the sum total of culturally patterned uses of the body in a society" (Csordas 1990:11). Bourdieu went further in elaborating that habitus is not simply patterned behavior, but also "a collection of practices, defining it as a system of perduring dispositions which is the unconscious, collectively inculcated principle for the generation and structuring of practices and representations" (Csordas 1990:11). All of these dispositions are internalized within the body and have an effect upon how a person goes about their everyday life. Bourdieu elaborates on how the senses help to construct the socially informed body. This is made up of the typical exteroceptive senses (sight, smell, touch, taste, and hearing), as well as the rest of the body's senses, such as common sense or the sense of beauty for example (Bourdieu 1977:124). As MacDougall has pointed out, "the social aesthetic field, composed of objects and actions, is in some respects the physical manifestation of... habitus" (1999). My research will explore the relationship between habitus of the seafarers, the aesthetics of a life at sea, and the role of time. By exploring the embodied histories of seafarers, I hope to understand how these social actors effect, and are effected by, the unique social aesthetic field found aboard ships. Also, including the concept of embodied *history* will tie directly into my exploration of how a person's aesthetic knowledge changes over time.

Previous research within the field of organizational studies has been conducted in order to explore the importance of aesthetics in shipboard life and work. Kathy Mack (2007:373) hoped to explore the aesthetic dimension of shipboard life and its relation to passion and knowledge. While I will also be looking at the relationship of aesthetic knowledge and working at sea, I will be approaching my project from a more anthropological perspective. My research will utilize a much more participatory approach than Mack's research. As a research project situated in the field of organizational studies, Mack's methods were based primarily upon the collection of data from respondents to a voluntary survey in a trade publication for merchant mariners. In the last section of my proposal I will highlight some of the methods with which I hope to tackle my proposed research. By using these methods, I hope to make meaningful contributions to the existing academic fields that I have discussed in this section.

RESEARCH METHODS

In the summer of 2008, I conducted research with fishermen and seafarers in the coastal regions of the Southeastern United States. The key informants of the project were members of the region's shrimping industry. The industry itself has been in steady decline over the past two decades, with 75% of the fleet having been lost over that period of time. During my fieldwork, I spent a month living at sea with a crew of shrimpers in order to gain a better understanding of their floating workplace, and why they chose to continue working in what they often described as a "dying" industry. Many of the informants that I met and spent time with at sea have been forced to leave fishing and move to other sectors of the maritime labor market. Oftentimes these men and women have found work in the major shipping ports in the area, such as the Port of Charleston or the Port of Georgetown. My past connections to members of the region's maritime labor industry will provide me with my initial access to commercial shipping vessels and their crews.

Once aboard the ships, I will look to build an informant pool from a variety of nations and cultural backgrounds. Shipping vessels offer an interesting setting for research into aesthetic knowledge, in that they are a truly multinational and multicultural work/dwelling place. Typically, an international shipping vessel's officers will come from nations that are considered to be traditional powers in the shipping industry, such as the United Kingdom, the United States, Norway, and Japan, just to name a few.³ Non-officer crewmembers, however, often hail from developing nations such as the Philippines, Liberia, and Indonesia. Given the cultural diversity on most vessels, this project will be able to investigate whether seafarers from different backgrounds have differing aesthetic experiences of the sea, or perhaps share a similar aesthetic experience, regardless of their background or heritage. As Tim Ingold points out, "there is one question that perhaps more than any other, motivates anthropological inquiry. Take people from different backgrounds and

³ See Alderton (2004), *The Global Seafarer: Living and Working Conditions in a Globalized Industry*.

place them in the same situation; they are likely to differ in what they make of it" (2000:157). It seems only fitting, then, to take advantage of a research setting that presents the opportunity to include informants from different backgrounds in the same workplace. By ensuring that I include informants from a variety of backgrounds, I hope to add an additional, almost ethnological, layer to my sensory ethnography's investigation of the relation between aesthetic knowledge and time.

My research will rely heavily upon one of the defining features of ethnographic research, participant observation. By spending an extended period of time living aboard ships with seafarers, I hope to gain a more full understanding of the embodied knowledge involved with working at sea. I will also, presumably, experience a shift in aesthetic knowledge over time, and thus be better informed in my discussion of the phenomenal field of seafaring.

The research will also incorporate the production of an ethnographic film. The project will utilize the observational filmmaking approach. As Anna Grimshaw points out, "observational cinema is a way of knowing, one located in the body and in the senses" (MacDougall and Grimshaw 2002:101). It seems only fitting then that a project focusing on sense experience utilize a research method that centers on the embodied, sensory experiences of the film's subjects.

Observational filmmaking will require "the rigorous observation of minute social events and interactions", and through this it will be "possible to gain significant insights, not just into idiosyncratic personal motivations of the immediate subjects, but also into broader social and cultural realities of their social world" (Henley 2004:134). The documentary will follow the journey of a sailor that is new to living and working at sea. By following a neophyte, I hope to touch upon aesthetic knowledge of a newcomer, and how that knowledge changes as his time at sea progresses.

By producing an ethnographic film project in conjunction with the written ethnography, I hope to be able to express different modes of knowledge in relation to the project. My written sensory ethnography will allow me to "tell" and explain the more implicit details involved in my sensory ethnography. The ethnographic film, however, will allow me to "show" the social and physical reality of seafaring. The film, I hope, will act as a way to draw readers closer to the perspective of the seamen involved in my research, while my written ethnography will be left to elaborate on the more technical aspects of the research. As Paul Henley points out, "cinema should be treated as a medium of suggestion and implication rather than of statement and description and the overall aim should be not to tell but to show. In this way, one ensures that a film remains not just an act of discovery for the maker, but also for the viewer who thereby participates actively in the construction of the meaning of the film" (2004:139). It is through the use of these methods that I hope to gain meaningful and new insights into the relationship between time and the aesthetics of seafaring.

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